

JACK'S STORY

7TH ARMORED DIVISION TANK COMMANDER
WORLD WAR II

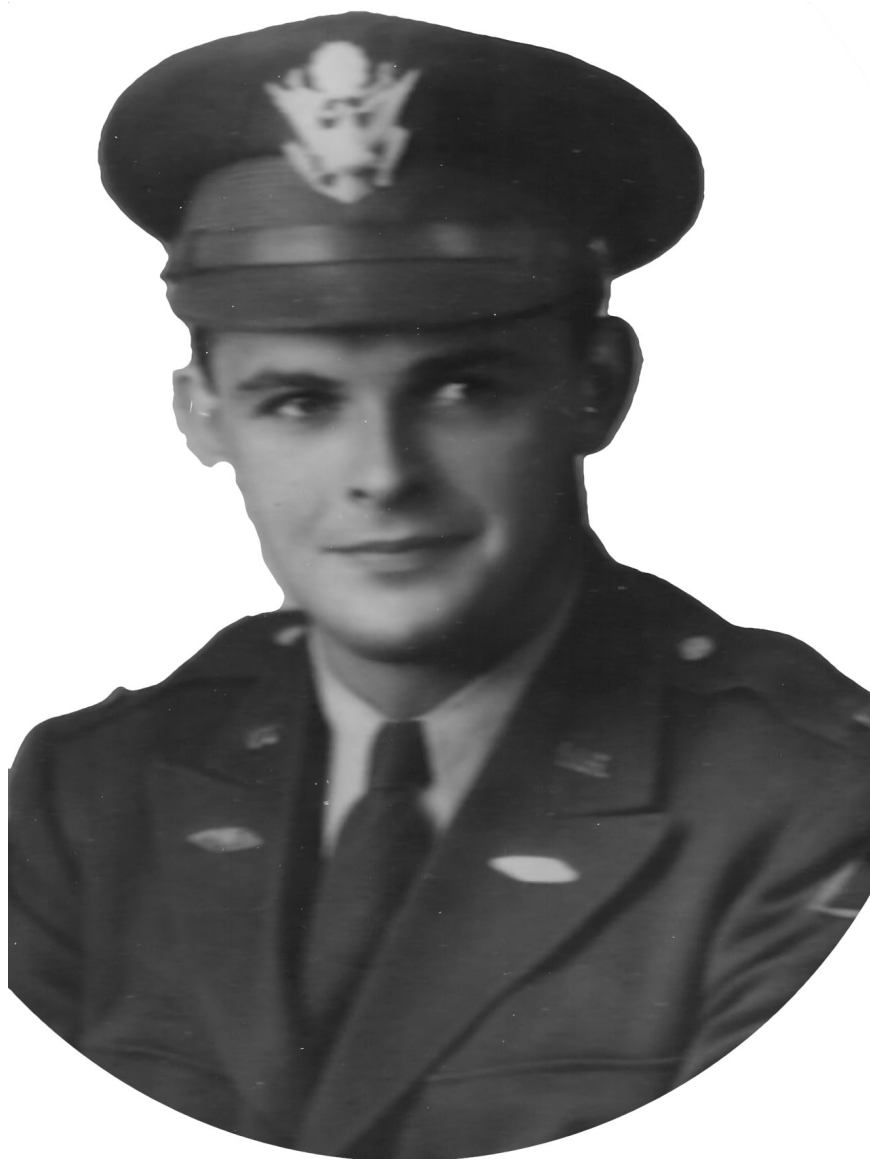
John H. Wilson

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Preface

Despite orders to “fight their way out,” the Company commander, Stan Nizinski, told the company, “We are surrendering.”

Lieutenant Jack Wilson, 1st Platoon leader, disagreed and pulled his M1911 .45 auto pistol on the commander.

* * *

On the 50th anniversary of D-Day, I wrote my father a letter which he shared with some friends.

His letter to his friends.

To whom it may concern:

I received the following letter from my son John in 1994. I was 73 years old and living in California at my son Willie's home along with Jeannie, my bride of 50 years.

June 3, 1994

Dear Dad:

I have been thinking a lot about you over this last week with Memorial Day and the 50th anniversary of D-Day. I am sure we all have private thoughts about what your generation went through 50 years ago.

I have always found it interesting that you have never talked much about your experiences during the war. Seeing a lot of the people interviewed on television about their experiences, they, too, have not shared their thoughts much.

Listening to the various stories about the invasion and the war, I get very choked up. I was fortunate to have not had the experience of war, and I certainly hope that my children do not.

I want to tell you that this is a special time to remember and to think about what my 23-year-old father was going through, starting 90 days after Normandy.

I love you, and you will always be a hero to me.
John

Jack continued in another note:

I had not shared the details of my service with my children, and his letter overwhelmed me as my thoughts returned to fighting in Europe from September 1944 through May 1945.

I received excellent responses. My closest friend since childhood, Frank Taylor, wrote, "Jack, you must share your story."

John C. [Jack] Wilson, Jr.

* * *

After this exchange, my father decided to share the wartime experiences he had kept to himself for nearly fifty years.

THIS IS JACK'S STORY

John H. Wilson

Jack's son

Introduction

My father's story did not begin with the war.

Jack Wilson grew up in Spokane, Washington, went to college, fell in love with Jean, got married, and was beginning a life much like that of other young men of his generation.

He entered the Army, became a tank officer, and eventually joined Company A of the 17th Tank Battalion, 7th Armored Division. He was 23 years old, newly married, with a baby on the way when he went into combat.

For years after the war, he said almost nothing about what happened.

The letter that opens this book, which I wrote to him on the 50th anniversary of D-Day, finally changed that. He began to tell me what he had experienced, and those memories became part of this book.

My father died on Christmas Day 1997. My mother, Jean, died in 2010. Years later, our family discovered more than one hundred letters she had saved from the war, and they were sent to me.

Those letters allowed me to hear my father's voice as a young man in a way I never had before. They told of his love for Jean, the men he commanded, his fears, and his humor. Sometimes they simply described what he had eaten or where he hoped to get a shower. Most important, they revealed his concern for the son he had never seen.

As I continued researching his story, I discovered something more.

The 7th Armored Division had played an important role in two major battles near the end of World War II in Europe. At St. Vith in December 1944, the division and the units fighting alongside it held up a much larger German force for seven days, disrupting the timetable of Hitler's last major offensive. Four months later, the 7th Armored helped close the Ruhr Pocket, where more than 300,000 German troops were captured. Few people know much about either battle.

Most people know the story of the Battle of the Bulge through Bastogne and the 101st Airborne. Far fewer know what happened at St. Vith, another critical road center only a short distance away.

During the German breakthrough, Eisenhower temporarily placed the American First and Ninth Armies north of the Bulge under British Field Marshal Bernard Montgomery. Bradley retained command of the forces to the south, including Patton's Third Army. In the histories written after the war, Bastogne became one of the battle's great stories. St. Vith never received the same attention.

The Ruhr Pocket had a different problem. It was one of the largest German defeats of the war, but it came in April 1945, when everyone knew the end was near. It never became one of the famous battles people still talk about today.

With the help of Wesley Johnston, historian of the 7th Armored Division Association, I was able to compare my father's letters and recollections with the division's after-action reports and other military records. Steven Smith, the book's original editor at Reedsy and a historian specializing in the Civil War and World War II, brought another perspective to the project. He is also the author of *Spearhead—2nd Armored Division: "Hell on Wheels."* His knowledge of military history helped me place Jack's experiences within the larger story of the war.

What began as an effort to understand my father's experiences became something larger. The letters revealed the young man he had been; the records revealed the history unfolding around him. The two could no longer be separated.

—John H. Wilson

Author's Note

Very different kinds of records helped put this story together. My father's response to my letter, written before his death, and his wartime letters home give me his voice, his humor, and what he was thinking and feeling at the time. The original after-action reports informed me where his battalion was, the battles they fought, and what those battles cost in equipment and men wounded or killed.

Putting this together allowed me to follow my father through the war. His letters tell us about the young man inside the tank. The military records tell us what was happening around him.

When my father speaks in these pages, the words are his, taken from his wartime letters or the account he wrote in 1995. I have lightly corrected spelling and punctuation in the letters for readability, but I have not rewritten them.

There were other experiences he didn't write about at the time. Some of the most difficult things he saw and did during the war he kept to himself for nearly fifty years. Eventually, he wrote some of them down in 1995 and talked about others with his children and grandchildren.

Where military records could add dates, places and details, I used them. Where the story was something only my father could have known—the things he saw, thought, feared, or remembered—I have told it as he gave it to us.

His original letters, military records, photographs, and awards have been donated to The National WWII Museum in New Orleans.

After all these years of letters, records, research, and family memories, I am telling his story as he lived it.

John H. Wilson

CHAPTER ONE

Let's Meet Jack Wilson

John C. (Jack) Wilson was born in Spokane, Washington. His father's family had migrated to Spokane from Toronto, Canada. They were pioneers in the Washington Territory, supplying meat for the railroad crews building the Great Northern Railroad. In 1916, Jack's father joined General Pershing in fighting Pancho Villa along the Mexican border, then fought in World War I, returning home as a First Sergeant. His mother's family was from Scotland and Ireland. Her father was a druggist who settled in Spokane in 1908.

When he was 11, in 1932, Jack's parents and his little sister, Carol Jean, moved to Seattle, a young city founded only 80 years earlier by the Arthur Denny Party that traversed the Oregon Trail after leaving Indiana. The Wilsons purchased a modest home on Queen Anne Hill just above Lake Union. They enjoyed views of the growing city, the docks along Elliott Bay of Puget Sound, and of majestic Mount Rainier to the south.

The Depression was devastating to the city's 350,000 residents. Unemployment soared, and many businesses went under, causing the heartbeat of Seattle to come to a dead stop. Thousands became homeless, so that "soup kitchens" became their main source of food, though hardly edible and lacking in life-supporting nutrition.



Seattle from Queen Anne Hill in the 1930s, where Jack grew up overlooking Lake Union and the growing city.

Hundreds of men lived in a shantytown known as a “Hooverville,” named after the former president. It was an unused shipyard south of Pioneer Square. They were very proud men, employed before the Depression, who had lost their homes and, in many cases, their families. They abhorred charity, built shanties, or lived in broken-down old cars. They had their own government, selecting a mayor and agreeing to strict rules, which they enforced among themselves. When the city government or other establishments tried to interfere, they loved to tweak them.

Between homelessness and so many others having a problem making ends meet, many illnesses plagued the city. One of the most impactful ones was typhoid fever, which hit many families. In the Wilson household, one of the most devastating things a family could experience happened when Jack’s little sister, Carol Jean, was struck with it. She did not survive and passed away when she was only 13.

His father was like the other hard workers who prided themselves on doing whatever was necessary for their families and community; one

Eastern magazine referred to them as “lumpy and dusty” people. He was a manufacturer’s rep for different food products. In 1944, with a partner, he started the Bergoust-Wilson Company, a food canning firm.

In 1935, Jack was entering his first year of high school when the federal government established a new program that would help him afford college. The National Youth Administration (NYA) was a relief agency for unemployed young adults and students. Around the state of Washington, students were paid to work in campus libraries and cafeterias, conduct research, and maintain buildings. By 1937, one in every ten students at the University of Washington held an NYA job.

The University recognized the increasing likelihood of American involvement in World War II and the national economic recovery that would come with wartime production, so it devoted all its effort to supporting the nation as it readied for war.

Jack was accepted to the University of Washington and enrolled in the fall of 1939. The beautiful campus covered over 500 acres in the University District of Seattle. It rose on several hills that looked out over Portage Bay directly south and Lake Union to the southeast.

Jack’s goal was to earn a bachelor’s degree in Business Administration. He enjoyed his college experience and became active in various organizations. He pledged and joined the Alpha Delta Phi fraternity, working in the kitchen to earn part of his housing expenses. That fall, influenced by his father’s military service and a desire to gain leadership skills, he joined the Army ROTC Basic program.

Jack jumped into the many service activities available in his first two years, as well as his schedule of classes. His dedication led to his selection at the beginning of his junior year for the Fir Tree Membership Medal, which was given to honor achievement in student activities.

He occasionally joined his parents on Sunday at the Unity Church at the foot of Queen Anne Hill for the 9:00 a.m. service. After church, he would go to the house for a late breakfast.

On Sunday, December 7, 1941, the church was warm with all the Christmas decorations, and church members were festive; he felt blessed to spend the day with them.

As his mother, Essie, prepared breakfast, his father turned the radio on to the local CBS affiliate, KIRO. It was a little past 11:00, and they were listening to “Spirit of ’41,” when host John Charles Daly was interviewing

guests from the Brooklyn Navy Yard. The two were paying little attention to the radio as Jack told his Dad about what was happening at college. At 11:30, the news program "The World Today" was to begin.

All of a sudden, a hissing sound lasted about 15 seconds, drawing their attention to the radio. John Daly came back on: "...the bulletin came: The White House just announced, the Japanese had attacked Pearl Harbor by air."

Carrier-borne planes from Japan had attacked the United States Naval Base at Pearl Harbor, killing more than 2,400 Americans. Eight battleships were sunk or badly damaged, including the USS Arizona, which was completely destroyed, and the USS Oklahoma, which capsized. Twelve other ships sank or were beached in the attack. Over 180 aircraft were destroyed and 160 others damaged.

The following day, President Roosevelt addressed a joint session of Congress. "Yesterday, December 7, 1941 — a date which will live in infamy — the United States of America was suddenly and deliberately attacked by the naval and air forces of the Empire of Japan."

The declaration of war on Japan changed everything. Germany and Italy declared war on the United States four days later. There was fear in Seattle of being attacked since it was one of the closest cities to Japan, and blackouts became mandatory.

In February 1942, President Roosevelt issued Executive Order 9066. Within weeks, some 10,000 people of Japanese descent in the Seattle area — most of them American citizens — were removed from their homes and placed in camps. Seattle's Japanese community was large, with many small business owners running hotels, restaurants, grocers, barbershops, and more. A large group of professionals also included doctors, lawyers, and architects. Many Seattle citizens were outraged because they were integral to the city.

Things moved quickly once war had been declared. The draft age dropped to 18, and many men and women immediately left college to volunteer for the Coast Guard, Navy, or Army. Countless men unemployed by the Depression also enlisted or found work in the newly busy armaments factories.

Jack decided, as did many of his young friends at the University, to further his training and education in hopes of becoming an officer. In the next 18 months, he would continue ROTC and be commissioned and

ready to serve his country. Some of his fellow students making the same decision would become lifelong friends through training and their war experiences. They included fraternity brothers Bill Bacon, Dixon Livingston, Jim Castle, and Frank Taylor.

He doubled down on his ROTC training program, studying strategy and tactics. He wanted to qualify for the Armor School at Fort Knox, so he devoured everything he could about tank combat.

Jack's participation in the Army ROTC program led to his winning the "Command and Leadership Award" in 1943. This award was given for excellence in leadership, academic achievements, and community service. Governor Arthur Langlie of Washington presented him with a saber to honor his accomplishment.

Jack had volunteered to be a manager of the crew team when enrolling at the university because his favorite sport was competitive rowing. Crew was a big-name sport for the Washington Huskies. In fact, the university's eight-man crew team had previously qualified to represent the United States in the 1936 Berlin Olympic Games, where they won the gold medal. It was chronicled in Daniel James Brown's beautiful 2013 book "The Boys in the Boat: Nine Americans and Their Epic Quest for Gold at the 1936 Berlin Olympics."

Over his four years at Washington, Jack worked closely with head coach Al Ulbrickson and the famous rowing shell builder George Pocock. As in all sports, teamwork was essential. Pocock said, "Rowing is perhaps the toughest of sports. Once the race starts, there are no time-outs and no substitutions. It calls upon the limits of human endurance. The coach must, therefore, impart the secrets of the special kind of endurance that comes from mind, heart, and body."

Coach Ulbrickson taught that leveraging individual strengths and perspectives would achieve collective success. He referred to it as, "Individuality is the ace up the sleeve of teamwork."

Jack's crew participation put him in the "Varsity Boat Club" and the "Big W Club," the University of Washington letterman's club.

He studied economics at the start of his junior year and noticed a very beautiful girl, a sophomore in the class; she really caught his eye. After seeing and talking to her in class, he asked her out. They dated over the next 18 months, and Jean became the love of Jack's life. They were an interesting pair, literally "from opposite sides of the tracks." Jack was

from a middle-class family in Seattle, while Jean was from a wealthy family in Spokane. They just clicked; Jean was sophisticated with a very dry and fun sense of humor, while Jack was the life of the party.

Francis Jean Fairweather, "Stormy," as her friends called her because of her last name, was born in Spokane, Washington, on April 1, 1922 (six months after Jack), to Han and Nell Fairweather.

Jean's grandfather, Hanford Wentworth Fairweather, Sr., also called "Han," was a pioneer in the Washington Territory from New Brunswick, Canada, arriving in 1871 at 28 years of age. He was involved with the Great Northern Railroad, real estate, politics, and banking. He was a delegate to the constitutional convention of 1889, the year Washington was admitted as a state."

Jean's family was fortunate as the Depression had little impact on them. She was an only child and lived an enviable life. The family also enjoyed a lake home at Twin Lakes, Idaho, about 40 miles east of Spokane. Jean spent the summers with her beautiful classic Chris-Craft speedboat.

In her later years, Kieran was Jean's only granddaughter, and they developed a close, warm relationship when Jean lived in New York with her daughter, Carol, and husband, Parker. Kieran had Jean laughing when she asked what Jack was like in college. Did he only go out with you? Grandma said, "He was quite the 'ladies' man,' but he was mine!"

Jean knew that Jack would go into the Army right after graduation, so that their immediate future would be difficult, especially with him going to war. Sure enough, upon graduation, Jack traveled to Fort Knox, Kentucky, south of Louisville, to start his 17-week Armor Officer Candidate School in basic armor.

He proposed to Jean that summer by sending her the above caricature (apart but together), and they began planning their January 12, 1944, wedding at St. John's Episcopal Cathedral in Spokane. In December, after training, Jack was commissioned as a Second Lieutenant and would remain at Fort Knox after the wedding.



“Apart but together.” Jack sent this caricature to Jean from Fort Knox when he proposed to her in the summer of 1943.

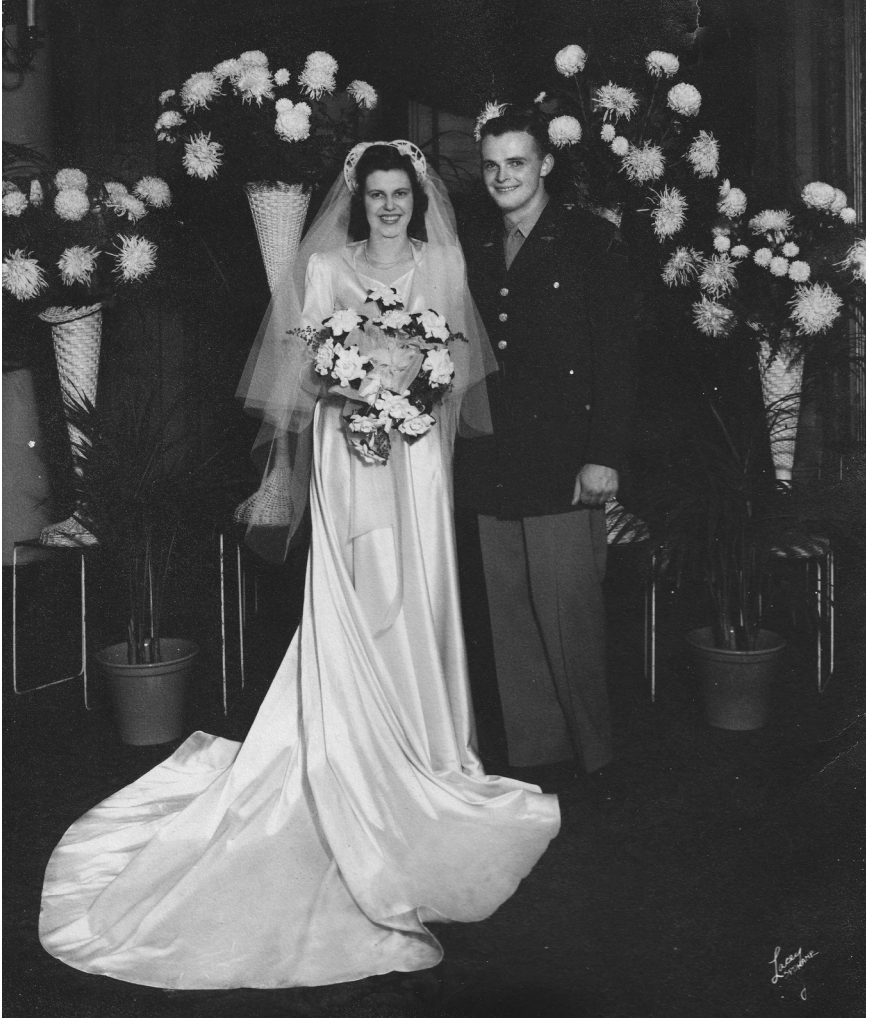
Jack and Jean were both looking forward to the wedding. On that Tuesday morning, they saw the Dean at the cathedral. After the evening rehearsal, there was a buffet at his aunt Georges’s home (his father’s sister). The wedding was held on Wednesday evening at St. John’s Cathedral; a champagne reception was held at the Davenport Hotel.

The wedding was a formal affair, with the ushers in uniforms or tuxes. Bill Bacon was Jack’s best man, and Bayard Young, Bob Ives, Bill Brubaker (Jean’s cousin), and Jim Castle were ushers. Jean’s father had already made train reservations for a Thursday morning return to Louisville. It was a very tight schedule!

Jack cut the six-tiered bride’s cake at the reception with the saber he was awarded for “Command and Leadership.”

Cutting the wedding cake with the saber would become a family tradition, with all of Jack and Jean’s children and grandchildren using it to cut their wedding cake.

BACK TO WORK



Jack and Jean on their wedding day, January 12, 1944, at St. John's Episcopal Cathedral in Spokane.

The couple departed for Fort Knox in Kentucky on Thursday morning, where Jack served in an armored training battalion.

Jean shared her impressions of Louisville with Jack's parents "Well, so this is Louisville. Frankly, I'm not impressed. I've never seen such dirt and filth in all my life. Everything is so old here; I can't get over it. I'm so

glad I'm with Jack; I don't see how he survived this town alone for five months."

By way of contrast, Jack's update to his parents about Louisville read "We found a lovely place to live. It is in an apartment hotel. As officers at Fort Knox, we are granted membership privileges at the Pendennis Club of Louisville. Last night, we had dinner and danced to the orchestra that played in the ballroom. At 12, we went to the Louisville Boat Club until 3 AM, then returned to the hotel. We met a lot of lovely kids, and Jean already had several invitations to lunch and dinner."

Jack worked six days a week and spent several nights on base sleeping on a couch.

"He was in bed by 8:00 most nights," Jean reported. She thought, "...he was so funny in his sleep; he drives tanks all night, gives orders, and I am black and blue where he has hit me in his sleep. I can't sleep because I'm laughing all night long at him. I try to keep out of his way as I figure I can sleep all day and he can't."

Their grandson, James, read this letter in 2024 and laughed since it explained the habits of his ten-year-old son Collin: "Now I know where his sleeping habits came from!"

Jean got a job as a filing clerk at the Goodyear Rubber Plant. She enjoyed it and was having fun working with the other girls. She was home by noon on Saturday, so she and Jack could enjoy his day off. The pay wasn't much, but it was helping with the expenses. She was also delighted with the new apartment.

Between Jack's friends and fellow officers, the new apartment became the fraternity house for Bill Bacon, Jim Castle, Dixon Livingston, and Chris Chrisman from South Carolina, who had become friends with them at Fort Knox. When off base, they would all show up at one time or another. They were all ready to party at the different clubs in town.

Jack's orders arrived on April 4th to report to Camp Cooke on the West Coast on April 18th. Jean left Louisville to return home and visit her parents in Spokane while Jack drove their car to the new base to arrange quarters nearby.

Camp Cooke, 65 miles north of Santa Barbara on the Pacific Ocean, was a 155-square-mile Army garrison established in 1941. The German Blitzkriegs early in World War II had clearly illustrated that a new and more deadly dimension had been added to modern warfare. In response

to this new threat, the US Army sought improved training centers to rapidly develop its armored, infantry, and artillery forces. The 11th Armored Division was deployed for this advanced training.

Jack arrived at Camp Cooke on April 17. He thought it was like sitting on a very barren, windy, and cold sandy hill. The weather was so rotten they didn't transition to summer khaki uniforms. "They say that even in summer, it only gets to the low 60s, and the wind is constant at 11 MPH."

He was assigned to Company C of the 22nd Tank Battalion as the maintenance officer. On his second night was called out with the company because a tank had lost one of its treads. When he arrived with a wrecker and crew, another tank had also lost a track; by the time they repaired the two treads and got them back in, it was 3:30 in the morning. The company had 18 tanks, but only seven were operational; his job was to get them all running!

The training continued with various problems that each platoon had to solve. Several evenings a week they attended officer meetings to discuss wartime strategy and tactics.

Jack wrote his parents about the intensified training they were going through at Camp Cooke. "We are working quite hard here; you can see that this outfit means business. I wrote up a problem to be solved dealing with anti-tank situations, and used dynamite to simulate anti-tank gunfire. The Battalion S-3 Officer (Planning and Training) was quite impressed."

He also gave them an update about Bill Bacon not going with the 9th Armored Division but to Camp Campbell in Tennessee with Jim Castle. Both had been assigned to the 12th Armored Division for advanced tank training.

Jack enjoyed the responsibilities he was given. He became Platoon Leader for the 3rd Platoon of C Company and served on the battalion board responsible for testing the combat ability of the different companies in the battalion. Part of the job was to construct problems for the tank platoons to solve. He found it exciting work and told his parents that he liked it better at Camp Cooke each week.

It was during this work that Jack met Master Sergeant Al Meyerson.

Meyerson was a veteran of Patton's North Africa campaign, one of the few combat-experienced NCOs assigned to train the new officers coming through Camp Cooke. He was in his mid-thirties, quiet, and watched

everything. The young lieutenants quickly learned that Meyerson had seen real combat, had lost men, and had no patience for officers who thought they knew more than they did.

Jack worked closely with Meyerson while creating combat problems for the platoons to solve. Over the weeks, the Master Sergeant began to share what he had learned in Africa—not tactics from a manual, but the things that kept men alive: how to read terrain, how to listen to your crew, and how to recognize when the situation on the ground was different from what headquarters believed.

One afternoon, after a training exercise, Meyerson pulled Jack aside.

“Your combat team has one question about any new young officer,” Meyerson said. “Would he get them killed?”

Jack listened.

“You will not have seen combat, and the regular combat troops want to be assured that the new officer isn’t set on the glory of killing the enemy and making a name for himself. They want to see that you can do your job and not be a ‘glory hunter.’ You must know that junior officers have to earn the respect of their men.”

Meyerson explained that a tank crew was completely interdependent—the commander, gunner, loader, driver, and assistant driver. Five men in thirty tons of steel, dependent on each other for survival.

“Work hard to be a good commander and encourage your crew to be as good as possible. Treat them with respect. Everybody has to do his job as best he can.”

Then he gave Jack the advice that would shape his approach to command.

“When you finally get your platoon command, listen closely and take the advice of your senior NCO. Let him command your platoon until you get some real leadership experience. You will gain the confidence required to command in combat.”

Jack took Meyerson’s words seriously. He had watched his father come home from the Great War and understood that combat changed men in ways that couldn’t be taught in a classroom. If a veteran like Meyerson said to trust his NCO, Jack would trust his NCO.

He would remember this advice six months later, standing in the mud of Holland, meeting his crew for the first time.

Jean joined Jack in mid-May after recovering from German measles while at home in Spokane. Due to housing scarcity, Jack and his training friend George Willhoitz decided to share a house to help with their expenses. George and Betty moved in with Jack and Jean.

Overseas, the war was raging, and Jack knew he would likely be deployed to Europe; it was only a matter of training and time.

At the end of May, they received the exciting news that Jean was pregnant with their first child. Both sets of “grandparents” were extremely excited to hear the news.

Several months of training at Camp Cooke went quickly, and Jack received his orders to report to Fort Meade, Maryland, by August 1, 1944. There, replacements for the front were being processed for transfer to Europe and the front lines.

It was mid-July, and they headed to Seattle to spend a few days with Jack's parents, and then to Spokane to see Jean's parents. Jack headed to Fort Meade, and Jean stayed at her parents' home in Spokane, waiting daily for her beloved Jack's letters.

JACK'S STORY

The opening ends here.

Jack has just left for Fort Meade, and Jean is waiting for his letters. What came next is the rest of the book: the stand at St. Vith in the Battle of the Bulge, the Ruhr Pocket, and the long road home.

Continue reading Jack's Story, available now in hardcover, paperback, ebook, and audiobook.

jwilsonbooks.com

A son. A soldier. A story of courage.